

Tortoises and turtles

Order Chelonia

Common snake-necked turtle

Chelodina longicollis

- ↔ 8–10 in (20–25 cm)
- 📍 S. New Guinea, N. Australia
- ⊗ Not known

With a neck nearly two-thirds the length of its shell when fully extended, this Australian river turtle has a long reach for catching invertebrates, frogs, and fish. Like other snake-necked turtles, it withdraws its neck sideways into

its shell—but cannot retract its head entirely. This turtle has earned the local name of “stinker” because it releases a foul-smelling defensive fluid when disturbed.



Matamata

Chelus fimbriata

- ↔ 12–18 in (30–45 cm)
- 📍 N. South America
- ⊗ Not known

Unlike other side-necked turtles, the matamata rarely swims in open water. Instead it stays still on the bottom of stagnant wetlands until prey gets close enough to grab with its wide mouth. Its bizarre fleshy adornments camouflage it against the background of weedy debris. In the shallows, its long neck can reach the surface to breathe with its tubular, snorkel-like snout. Female matamatas lay up to 28 eggs in a single nesting.

Loggerhead turtle

Caretta caretta

- ↔ 28–39 in (71–100 cm)
- 📍 Tropical, subtropical, and temperate waters worldwide
- ⊗ Endangered

The world’s biggest, hard-shelled sea turtle is named for its large head, armed with powerful jaws for crunching crustaceans and mollusks. Like all other sea turtles, its limbs are modified into flippers for swimming, but females must “beach” themselves to lay eggs. Loggerheads breed only every two years—sometimes longer.

Alligator snapping turtle

Macrochelys temminckii

- ↔ 16–32 in (40–80 cm)
- 📍 SE. US
- ⊗ Vulnerable

The weightiest freshwater turtle is an aggressive predator. It crawls along the bottom of swamps for prey, waiting among water weed with its mouth open. A wriggling appendage on its tongue then lures fish in. To make a catch, the turtle’s head shoots forward and the jaws snap with a powerful bite.

European pond turtle

Emys orbicularis

- ↔ 6–8 in (15–20 cm)
- 📍 N. Africa, Europe, W. Asia
- ⊗ Near threatened

This species ranges further north than most other freshwater turtles, and populations in the coldest parts survive the winter by hibernating in shallow water. Typical of many reptiles, this turtle routinely basks in the sun. It spends more time on land than other, more strictly aquatic, species—often wandering miles away from wetlands.

Leatherback sea turtle

Dermochelys coriacea

- ↔ 4–6 ft (1.2–1.8 m)
- 📍 Tropical, subtropical, and temperate waters worldwide
- ⊗ Vulnerable

This jellyfish-eating predator is the biggest of all turtles—and the fastest swimming reptile. Its muscles generate enough body heat to stay active even in the cold ocean. Its blood circulation also traps this heat close to vital organs, giving it the stamina to dive deep and travel far.

African helmeted turtle

Pelomedusa subrufa

- ↔ 8–13 in (20–33 cm)
- 📍 Sub-Saharan Africa
- ⊗ Not known

This turtle can retract its neck completely by folding it sideways under the leading edge of the shell. It is an opportunistic marshland predator and will even grab birds that come down to drink, pulling them underwater to drown them. It lives in rain pools and watering holes in Africa’s open country. During the rainy season, it wanders from pool to pool foraging for prey. It may estivate in dry conditions by burying itself in mud.

Red-footed tortoise

Chelonoidis carbonaria

- ↔ 16–20 in (41–51 cm)
- 📍 N. to C. South America
- ⊗ Not known

This tortoise ranges widely in South American grasslands and open woodland, but is absent from the wettest parts of the Amazon basin. The orange or yellow color pattern is highly variable, and a closely allied species—the yellow-footed tortoise (*C. denticulata*)—may occur in the same habitat. This group of tropical American tortoises also includes the ancestors of the giant tortoises of the Galapagos Islands.

Indian star tortoise

Geochelone elegans

- ↔ Up to 11 in (28 cm)
- 📍 S. Asia
- ⊗ Common

Named for the striking pattern on its shell, this tortoise lives in dry scrubby forests, where its yellow, starlike markings camouflage it



against the leaf litter on the forest floor as it feeds on grasses and low-growing succulent plants. The plates of its shell are raised into distinct peaks—which help the animal to right itself if it falls on its back. This tortoise needs plenty of water and is most active during the monsoon season. In drier weather, it stirs only in the morning and late afternoon.

Other species

- Common snapping turtle
Chelydra serpentina » p73
- Galapagos tortoise
Chelonoidis elephantopus » p127
- Green sea turtle
Chelonia mydas » p346
- Leopard tortoise
Stigmochelys pardalis » p227